

"I don't want to be a leader. I want to be one who goes around with a little oil can and offer help when I see a breakdown."

Baba Amte

Activist 1914-2008

■ By Medha Patkar

The nonagenarian social worker leaves behind a tradition of struggle and reconstruction devoted to the uplift of society and empowerment of the disabled. A man with a spirited vision of building a just and sustainable society, he had deep faith in nature and humanity. Every individual, whether impaired, physically disabled or a *kushthrogi* (leprosy patient) was for him a source of energy that needed to be harnessed. "Youth is he who rises to the sky limit and allows himself to sublime," was Baba's understanding and also a basic tenet of his inimitable relationship with the blooming generation.

Anandvan—an ashram set up for leprosy patients in Chandrapur, Somnath camp—a source of inspiration for youth, Hemal Kasa—a centre for adivasis in Gadchiroli district, Maharashtra, today stand as successes that can weave the micro into the macro vision of transformation.

Born as Muralidhar Devdas Amte and an advocate by profession, he not only had a firm belief in the ideologies of Mahatma Gandhi, Vinoba Bhave, and other humanitarian philosophers, but also a unique ability to transform their ideals into practice. He spent his entire life with a family—that of *kushthrogis*, who proved social assets. A right choice of technology and contribution of innovative ways of managing resources were the strength of his approach. He was firmly opposed to large dams, which made him camp on the Narmada bank for a decade with a courageous position and committed involvement. Even in the face of patently false allegations and repressive force used against the people

of the Narmada valley and their two-decade-long struggle, Baba challenged the State and took to streets with farmers, labourers and adivasis.

His activism was a reflection of his faith in action, not just words. He was in the thick of things when violence struck Punjab or riots took place in Mumbai or Bhagalpur. His plea for Bharat Jodo touched the hearts of millions because it was a sincere, confident attempt to bury evils that divided humankind.

Development for life and livelihood was Baba's dream that made him a supporter of people's movements like those for saving land and resources. He supported adivasis against the Ichampalli Bhopalapatnam dam, not caring about being branded a naxalite or an anti-national. A messiah of non-violence, his spirit was militant which he exhibited in his critique as well as rejection of awards over the Narmada issue. Yet, Baba was bestowed with many awards by power holders, probably to cleanse their own conscience.

I still remember Baba's support to every fast of mine and our activists, and yet he staunchly opposed our sitting on jal samadhi. He was against fasting since he knew about its physical impacts as well. Yet he never stopped me and others. He was always an inspirer, a facilitator but never a dictator. Despite their worries and concerns, he and his wife Sadhana Tai, would wish us well. His ways were never apolitical, yet his response to the vulgar moves of the politicians of Gujarat was to join our satyagraha. But he also shared with us that he had dreamt of our going under water, hitting the dam wall.

Baba's unique stature made him a

true companion of eminent scientists, artists, intellectuals, activists and philosophers, including the Dalai Lama, P.L. Deshpande and others from abroad. Even when he was bedridden for years, he was abreast of the latest events, happenings and conflicts around the world. He was sensitive to even the slightest of turmoil, not to speak of wars and calamities. Baba's poetic as well as political statements and radical plans infected all those who were sensitive enough to take the bits of his vision into their own careers and life.

Baba left the world amidst commotion, created by the state and elite sections of society—a consequence of value degradation in politics and in the economy with a materialistic perspective of progress, as well as the resultant enslavement of society. He used to fiercely critique all this and yet transmitted hope with every seed of thought and action that he had sown. His soul may or may not have rested in peace when his body, wrapped in plantain leaves, merged with the earth, rejecting all rites and rituals, on February 10. He, however, did not miss any of his worldly duties, including sharing not just love, but respect for his wife, and all women, as also caring for the family, with his great sons, Vikas and Prakash, daughters, grandsons, all enveloped in his missionary bondage. The larger family of Baba's *biradari*, activists and local to global humane citizenry, too has to take a pledge to take his legacy forward to build the nation as he would have wanted to.

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